sticking with her initial acceptance of the Swaran Singh formula. How credible can one consider Alexander's terming of these reports as 'mischievous', when he has himself completely omitted the most crucial round of mediated talks from his book?

In fact, the deliberate omission of reference to the Swaran Singh-mediated solution is not just limited to Alexander's book. A cover-up to remove its traces began as early as July 1984 with the Central government's white paper on Punjab, which was tabled in parliament within one month of Operation Blue Star. Noting the total absence of reference to the Swaran Singh-mediated talks in the paper, senior BJP leader, and later prime minister, Atal Bihari Vajpayee stated in parliament on 25 July 1984, 'there is no reference (in the white paper) to the efforts made by Sardar Swaran Singh. Has the Congress disowned even Sardar Swaran Singh? Did he make any efforts or did he not?' [6] .

Alexander was one of the members of the three-man think-tank and, in his capacity as principal secretary to the PM, was in a position to influence the views of the other two by dropping subtle hints as to what his boss would appreciate. Also, all three members of the think-tank (Alexander, Cabinet Secretary C.R. Krishnaswamy Rao Sahib and Home Secretary Chaturvedi) were highly experienced officers who, as the saying goes in Urdu, 'could count the feathers of a flying sparrow'.

They knew very well the Indian bureaucratic ways of holding and prolonging fruitless discussions, best described by the dictum '*naksha,* meeting *aur salaam'* – which means prepare maps or collect a lot of relevant data, hold protracted discussions without conceding anything substantial while keeping the hope of another session alive. Unfamiliar as the think-tank was with Punjab affairs to begin with, it would not have been difficult for them to work out an amicable solution to the Punjab imbroglio, provided only that there was a suitable signal from the top.

Spymaster R.N. Kao

Rameshwar Nath Kao (IP 1940 United Provinces), a role model for the second category of bureaucrat, was recalled by Indira Gandhi